Pre-Historic India

1. Read the evidence first

- **History**: Greek *historia* = inquiry/knowledge acquired by investigation.
- **Prehistory**: before usable written records; reconstructed through tools, settlements, bones, plant remains, burials and art.
- **Protohistory**: a transitional category—writing is undeciphered, or a society is known through another literate society/oral tradition. **Harappan script remains undeciphered; Mesopotamian texts supply external evidence.** Vedic oral traditions and some Neolithic–Chalcolithic cultures are included in broader textbook usages; definitions vary.
- **Historical period**: written evidence can be read alongside archaeology. These categories do not begin everywhere at one date.

Sources → what they reveal

Evidence	Recall and use
Vedas	Rig: mainly hymns; Sama: chants; Yajur: sacrificial formulae; Atharva: spells, rites and everyday concerns. Broad textbook composition range c.1500–500 BCE, not one composition date.
Upanishads; Sutras	Upanishads/Vedanta: Atman–Brahman, philosophical inquiry. Shrauta and Grihya Sutras: public sacrificial and domestic rites.
Epics; Buddhist/Jain texts	Ramayana, Mahabharata; Pali Tipitaka: **Vinaya** discipline, **Sutta** discourses, **Abhidhamma** systematic doctrine. Jain Angas in Prakrit/Ardhamagadhi preserve religious ideas.
Law and administration	Dharmashastras, e.g. Manusmriti: prescribed social duties; **prescription ≠ proof of actual practice**. Kautilya's Arthashastra: statecraft/economy; a layered text, not a transparent contemporary Mauryan report.
Grammar and literature	**Panini—Ashtadhyayi**; **Kalidasa—Abhijnanashakuntalam, Ritusamhara, Meghadutam**; social/cultural evidence read in literary context.
Historical narratives	**Kalhana—Rajatarangini**, 12th-century Kashmir; **Banabhatta—Harshacharita**, court biography of Harsha. Patronage and praise can shape accounts.
Tamil literature	Sangam poetry illuminates early Tamil society, economy and polity; broad conventional span c.300 BCE–300 CE. **Silappadikaram and Manimekalai are later/post-Sangam epics**, not securely dated to that entire range.
Inscriptions	Epigraphy: engraved stone/metal records; Ashokan policy, Satavahana grants. **Prashasti = eulogy**, not every inscription. Read issuer, purpose and findspot.
Coins	Numismatics: economy/trade, rulers, scripts, religion, art and metallurgy. Early **punch-marked silver/copper** coins; Indo-Greek portraits and legends. **Large-scale gold coinage is especially associated with Kushans**. RBI coin museum.

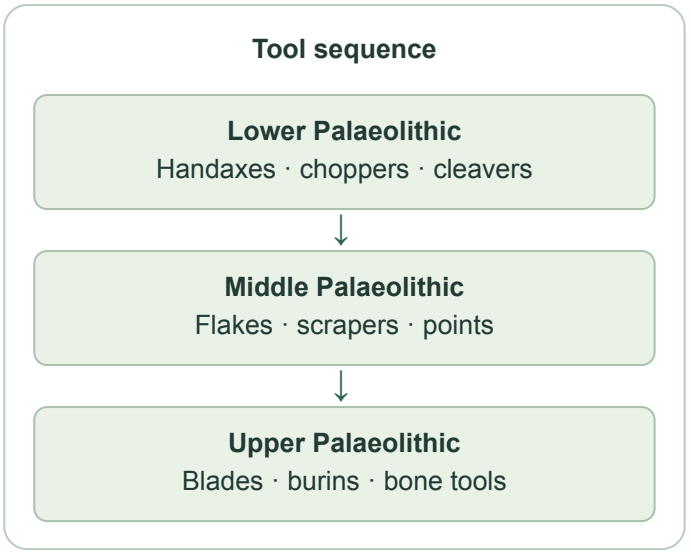
Excavation	Stratigraphy, houses, tools, pottery and megalithic graves reveal material life; megaliths are especially associated with the south Indian **Iron Age**, not only “before 300 BCE”.
Environmental/genetic evidence	Pollen, seeds, fauna and geology reconstruct diet, farming and environment; mitochondrial DNA traces maternal lineages/migrations. Context and dating remain essential.
Foreign accounts	**Megasthenes—Indica**, Mauryan society/administration; **Periplus of the Erythraean Sea** (anonymous, 1st century CE) and **Ptolemy—Geography** (2nd century CE): ports/trade. **Faxian: early 5th century CE**, Gupta era; **Xuanzang: 7th century CE**, Harsha/Nalanda—not 500/700 CE as exact visit dates.

2. Stone Age: the comparison to remember

Tools + subsistence + site context define a culture; dates overlap between regions.

Phase	Tool cue	Economy and settlement
Palaeolithic / Old	Handaxes/cleavers → flakes → blades/burins	Hunting–gathering; mobile groups, open sites, caves/rock shelters
Mesolithic / Middle	**Microliths**, often hafted into composite tools	Hunting, fishing, gathering; temporary/semi-permanent camps; herding/cultivation develop in some later contexts
Neolithic / New	**Ground/polished celts**, continued chipped tools	Farming + herding, settled villages, storage, pottery in many phases
Chalcolithic / Copper–Stone	**Copper + stone**, occasional bronze	Mostly rural agropastoral settlements, specialised crafts/exchange

- Book's broad revision bands: Palaeolithic **c.500,000–10,000 BCE**; Mesolithic **c.10,000–6000 BCE**; Neolithic **c.6000–1000 BCE**; Chalcolithic **c.3000–500 BCE**. **These are teaching ranges, not uniform or definitive boundaries**; Mehrgarh's conventional earlier chronology itself falls outside the Neolithic band.
- **Pleistocene**: repeated glacial/interglacial cycles; India was not entirely ice-covered. **Holocene begins about 11,700 years ago**, broadly overlapping later foragers and early farming societies. “Years ago” is not interchangeable with BCE. ICS chronology.
- At **Attirampakkam, Tamil Nadu**, a dated transition to Middle Palaeolithic technology occurs around **385 ±64 thousand years ago**, with that sequence continuing to **172 ±41 ka**. This is a **site-specific scientific chronology**, not a universal 385,000–40,000 BCE range. Research paper.



3. Palaeolithic: hunters and gatherers

- Flaked, generally unpolished tools; quartzite widely used, hence the old label **“quartzite men”**—a tool-material label, not a biological population.
- Hunting, gathering wild plant foods and, where available, aquatic resources; no established farming or metal industry. Fire use predates the Mesolithic globally; exact local evidence must be checked.
- **Lower**: heavy handaxes, choppers, cleavers—cutting, digging, skinning. **Middle**: smaller flake tools—scrapers, borers, points. **Upper**: parallel-sided blades, burins, bone tools and ornament/art evidence.
- **Robert Bruce Foote**: Pallavaram handaxe, **1863**; extensive south Indian surveys. Mortimer Wheeler contributed excavation methods and cultural sequencing. H.D. Sankalia's work at **Nevasa** helped identify the “Nevasan” Middle Palaeolithic industry.
- Do not infer a single hominin species, race or exact language capacity from tools. **Homo sapiens originated in Africa about 300,000 years ago**, not at the end of the Upper Palaeolithic; human evolution is branching, not a simple ladder through Neanderthals. Smithsonian.

Site clusters

Region / site	Link to remember
Soan/Sohan valley, Potwar plateau; Sanghao cave	Pakistan; Lower/Middle traditions; **Potwar lies between Indus and Jhelum**
Didwana, Jayal, Budha Pushkar, Luni	Rajasthan/Thar; early tool traditions and environmental change
Hiran valley; Visadi, Umrethi	Gujarat; Palaeolithic distribution
Bhimbetka, Adamgarh, Samnapur	Madhya Pradesh; shelters and long sequences; Narmada region
Belan valley, Lalitpur; Son valley—Baghor, Sihawal	Uttar Pradesh and adjoining central India; **Belan preserves successive Palaeolithic–Mesolithic–Neolithic evidence**
Paisra; Chhotanagpur; Damodar basin	Eastern India; tools and settlement evidence

Patne, Bori, Nevasa, Gangapur	Maharashtra; **Patne: Upper Palaeolithic ostrich-eggshell/ornament evidence**
Hunsgi, Anagwadi, Kovalli; Tungabhadra valley	Karnataka/southern peninsula; important lithic localities
Kurnool caves, Muchchatla Chintamanu Gavi, Betamcherla	Andhra Pradesh; notable Upper Palaeolithic bone-tool evidence
Nagarjunakonda, Nandipalle, Vodikalu, Renigunta	Andhra Pradesh; peninsula's wider tool distribution
Pallavaram, Attirampakkam, Gudiyam	Tamil Nadu; discoveries and dated evidence refute blanket absence from southern India

4. Mesolithic: microliths, mobility and art

- **Microliths**: small geometric/non-geometric chipped tools, often chert, chalcedony or other cryptocrystalline silica. **Not characteristically polished**; insert in wood/bone handles for arrowheads, spearheads, knives and sickles.
- Warming environments and diverse ecological niches supported smaller-game hunting, fishing and gathering. Some communities became more settled; food production emerged unevenly, not everywhere at once.
- Burial with grave goods suggests ritual/social ideas; it cannot by itself prove a particular belief system.

Site	Distinctive recall
Bagor, Kothari river, Rajasthan	Large, well-documented Mesolithic settlement; animal-domestication evidence
Adamgarh, Madhya Pradesh	Important early herding/domestication evidence; avoid an unqualified worldwide “first”
Mahadaha, Uttar Pradesh	Bone arrowheads/ornaments; paired male–female burial
Sarai Nahar Rai; Damdama, Pratapgarh region, UP	Camps, burials and forager life
Langhnaj, Mehsana, Gujarat	Microlithic occupation and burials; pottery in later contexts. **Langhnaj is not in UP**; Kaimur is a separate region.
Chopani Mando, Morhana Pahar, Lekhahia	Belan–Vindhyan/UP region; long forager-to-village transitions, some pottery-bearing contexts
Birbhanpur; Paisra/Kuchai; Chhotanagpur	West Bengal and eastern sites
Tilwara, Dhaneri, Kanawas; Tarsang, Devnimori	Rajasthan–Gujarat clusters
Pachmarhi, Putlikarar; Chitrakot falls	Central Indian distribution
Patne, Pachad; Gauri Gundam, Kondapur, Renigunta	Deccan and southern distribution

Sanganakallu, Jalahalli; Calicut, Malampuzha, Tenmalai	Karnataka–Kerala microlithic localities; Tirunelveli adds Tamil Nadu

Rock art: a ready Mains example

- **Bhimbetka—Vindhyan hills, Raisen district, MP**: multiple periods of occupation/painting; V.S. Wakankar identified the shelters in **1957–58**. **A.C. Carlleyle's 1867–68** discoveries mark early documentation of Indian rock paintings, not their prehistoric creation dates.
- Other clusters: Kaimur/Mirzapur; Kharwar, Jaora, Kathotia (MP); Sundargarh/Sambalpur (Odisha); Ezhuthu Guha (Kerala).
- **Themes**: group hunts, fishing, dances, honey/fruit gathering, food preparation, family/community scenes. Bison, buffalo, deer, nilgai, elephant, rhino and big cats; bows, arrows, barbed spears, pointed sticks. Some contexts suggest ritual or work roles; these remain interpretations.
- **Aesthetics**: dynamic movement, rhythmic group composition, naturalistic animals and stylised/stick-like humans; narrative economy rather than academic realism.
- Red and white dominate; mineral pigments, e.g. **haematite → red**, with other colours also present. Superimposition helps establish relative sequence; **all Bhimbetka art is not Mesolithic**. NCERT art chapter.

5. Neolithic: the food-producing transition

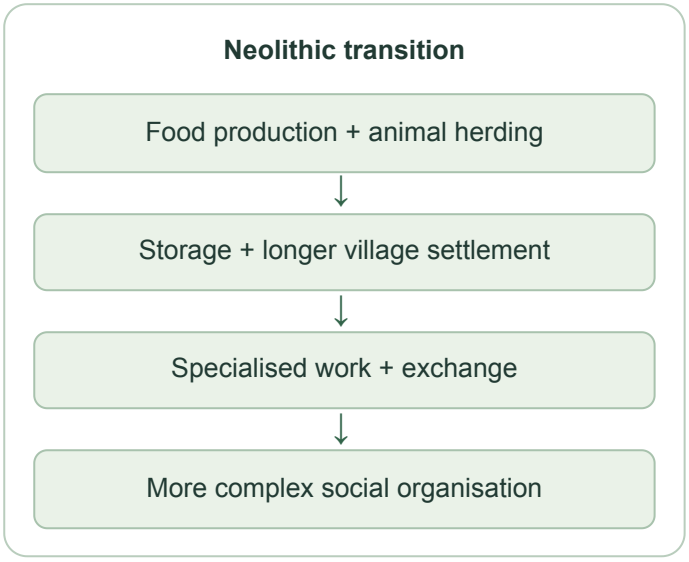
- **V. Gordon Childe—"Neolithic Revolution"**: profound change in subsistence and social life; a prolonged, regionally varied process rather than a sudden worldwide event.
- Farming + cattle/sheep/goat herding; hunting/gathering continued. Regional crops include wheat/barley, rice and pulses; southern farming included millets and horse gram. **"Corn" can mean grain, not necessarily American maize**; ragi and horse gram are not maize.
- Ground, pecked and polished stone axes/celts; tools for clearing/cultivating, continued blades/scrapers and bone implements. Early handmade pottery, later wheel use in suitable contexts; black-burnished, grey, mat-/cord-impressed wares vary by region. **Aceramic Neolithic phases exist**.
- Circular/rectangular mud-and-reed houses; storage and more durable villages; spinning/weaving and specialised work develop in suitable contexts. Division of labour and exchange increased; do not assume every village was isolated or entirely self-sufficient.

Food production → storage → longer settlement → specialised work/exchange → more complex social organisation. Each link is a tendency, not an inevitable one-way law.

Region / site	Distinctive evidence
Mehrgarh, Kachi plain, Bolan pass, Balochistan (Pakistan)	Early farming before urban Harappa; mudbrick architecture, wheat/barley, cattle/sheep/goats, cotton in later evidence, drilled teeth. **Conventional textbook beginning c.7000 BCE**; initially aceramic. Official site description.
Burzahom, Kashmir	Pit dwellings; stone/bone tools, burials involving humans and animals including dogs; distinctive rectangular stone chopper. Do not infer every dog was buried with a master.
Gufkral, Kashmir	Pit dwellings; stone tools and burial evidence; farming/herding. Kashmir's phases overlap Harappan times without being identical cultures.
Chirand, Bihar	Rich antler/bone-tool industry; **antlers ≠ true horns**

Koldihwa; Mahagara, Belan valley, UP	Huts, handmade pottery, rice-related evidence; Mahagara cattle-pen evidence. Koldihwa has Neolithic–Chalcolithic–Iron Age sequence. **Not established as the world's earliest rice cultivation**.
Chopani Mando, Belan valley	Early pottery-bearing forager/village-transition contexts; not an unquestioned worldwide pottery “first”
Senuwar/Senwar, Bihar; eastern sites	Gangetic/eastern traditions, cord-marked pottery in relevant contexts and links towards eastern/southeastern Asia
Maski, Brahmagiri, Piklihal, Tekkalakota, Karnataka	Cattle-herding settlements; southern Neolithic ash-mound tradition
Budihal, Karnataka	Community food preparation/feasting and pastoral settlement evidence; **not Andhra Pradesh**
Utnur, Telangana; Nagarjunakonda, AP	Southern pastoral/farming traditions; ash mounds at Utnur
Paiyampalli, Tamil Nadu; Hallur, Karnataka	Important south Indian Neolithic localities
Daojali Hading, Assam; Garo hills, Meghalaya	Northeastern Neolithic; ground tools/cord-impressed traditions. Book's broad later horizon **c.2500–1500 BCE or later**, with site-level variation.
Sarai Khola, Potwar (Pakistan)	Northwestern settlement sequence; do not classify all Amri/Kot Diji material as Neolithic—these are prominently Early Harappan sites.

Dating caution—Mehrgarh: a **2025 tooth-enamel radiocarbon study** challenges the conventional chronology, placing its Period I approximately **5250–4650 cal BCE**. Keep the familiar c.7000 BCE textbook date labelled conventional, and this result labelled a research revision; neither is a date for the beginning of all South Asian agriculture. Primary study.



6. Chalcolithic: copper with stone

- **Chalcos = copper; lithos = stone.** Rural copper–stone cultures can precede, overlap or follow Harappan phases; **not all are pre-Harappan** and not all pre-Harappan societies were copper-using.

- Widespread in Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP, Maharashtra; also eastern/southern regions. Compare rural non-Harappan communities with the **urban Bronze Age Harappan civilisation**, which also included villages.
- Agriculture, stock-rearing, fishing/hunting: wheat/barley more prominent in many western contexts; rice/fish in eastern ones; regional millets and pulses—lentil, black/green gram, grass pea. Cotton cultivation/spinning in suitable black-soil areas; slash-and-burn used in some settings, not a universal system.
- Cattle, sheep, goats, pigs and buffalo; deer hunted. **Copper was not the only known metal**: occasional bronze, gold and silver also occur. Avoid blanket claims that every community lacked dairy use or horses, or that no cultivation implements existed anywhere.
- Painted pottery, **black-and-red ware**, regional red wares and OCP-related horizons are key material markers; decorative styles vary. Potter's wheels and other techniques coexist; no secure universal rule assigns wheel use only to men.
- Mainly mud/wattle-and-daub or mudbrick homes, often thatched; circular and rectangular plans. **Stone foundations/houses at Ahar**; burnt brick occurs at some sites such as **Gilund**—"no Chalcolithic burnt bricks" is too absolute. University of Mumbai archaeology text.
- Copper smelting, stone-working, beads (carnelian, steatite, quartz), shell/bone ornaments, combs, spinning/weaving; exchanges link villages and larger centres. **Ahar copper → neighbouring Malwa/Gujarat exchange** is a useful regional example.
- House size, storage/public works and unequal grave goods suggest social differentiation; they do not prove the same political system everywhere. Inamgaon-type water-management structures suggest coordinated activity.
- Female figurines often interpreted as fertility/mother-goddess symbols; bull figurines suggest animal symbolism. **Interpretation ≠ proof of a fixed pantheon, female supremacy or "inferior male gods".** Grave goods may indicate ritual/afterlife concepts.
- Numerous child burials in western Deccan contexts indicate substantial child mortality, but burial samples do not directly give a population-wide mortality rate.

Culture → river → site

Culture	Approximate book chronology	Geography / major sites
Ahar–Banas	c.2600–1900 BCE	Banas basin, SE Rajasthan; **Ahar** near Udaipur; **Gilund**, Balathal
Kayatha	c.2100–2000 BCE	**Chhoti Kali Sindh**, Chambal drainage, MP; Kayatha
Prabhas	c.1800–1400 BCE	Prabhas Patan/Somnath, Gujarat
Malwa	c.1700–1400 BCE	**Navdatoli—Narmada**, western MP; wider regional links
Jorwe	c.1400–700 BCE	Maharashtra: **Jorwe—Pravara**, **Inamgaon—Ghod**, **Daimabad —Pravara**, Chandoli; all are not on one river

Chronologies differ by excavation and phase; these ranges are reference bands, not fixed dates for every associated site.

Site	High-yield association
Ahar	Copper smelting/metallurgy; stone construction

Gilund	Ahar–Banas settlement, occasional burnt brick
Nevasa; Eran	Maharashtra/MP, non-Harappan Chalcolithic
Navdatoli	Malwa culture; diverse cultivated crops
Daimabad, Godavari drainage	Large settlement; famous bronze hoard—**chariot with driver, elephant, rhinoceros, buffalo**. Hoard attribution/date requires context; not every bronze belongs securely to Jorwe.
Songaon, Inamgaon, Nasik	Deccan houses, hearths/ovens and varied settlement forms
Kayatha	Copper cutting tools, distinctive pottery, mud-plastered floors; cultural affinities do not establish that the whole phase predates Harappa
Malwa sites	Elaborate ceramics, spindle whorls; non-Harappan village tradition
Chirand, Senuwar, Sonpur	Bihar regional sequences
Pandu Rajar Dhibi, Mahishdal	West Bengal Chalcolithic
Narhan; Ganeshwar/Jodhpura	UP regional sequence; Rajasthan copper-related sites
Prabhas Patan, Rangpur	Gujarat regional/Harappan-contact sequences; phase-specific classification

- **Burial contrasts described in the chapter**: north–south at several Maharashtra sites; east–west at some southern sites; fractional/secondary burial in some eastern contexts. These are regional observations, not exclusive rules for whole regions.

7. PYQ and answer framework

UPSC CSE Mains 2015 · GS I · Question 2 · 12½ marks · 200 words

“Mesolithic rock cut architecture of India not only reflects the cultural life of the times but also a fine aesthetic sense comparable to modern painting. Critically evaluate this comment.”

- **Interpret the wording through rock-shelter paintings**; Mesolithic art is not the later excavated Buddhist/Hindu/Jain cave-temple architecture.
- **Culture**: hunting technology/group cooperation; fishing/food gathering; dance, family and food preparation; possible ritual and work roles.
- **Aesthetics**: selective lines, naturalistic animals, stylised people, movement, rhythm, composition, red/white contrast and storytelling. Use Bhimbetka examples.
- **Critical balance**: comparison concerns expressive quality, not identical technique, purpose or social setting. Different periods overlap; ritual/gender readings need corroboration.
- **Conclusion**: both a material record of community life and an accomplished visual language; protect fragile sites.

Practice: avoid the printed-key traps

- **Q4**: the claim that tiny flaked blades/burins define Neolithic technology and that horse domestication is a universal Neolithic marker is unsafe; the printed **(a)** is not a reliable answer. Pottery alone does not make the supplied options sound.

- **Q5**: “all pre-Harappan cultures are Chalcolithic” is false; retain only the qualified statement about some pre-/post-Harappan copper–stone cultures.
- **Q6**: “paintings depict religious beliefs” is an interpretation; the question's single-answer wording is not rigorous.
- **Q9**: megaliths are especially linked with the southern **Iron Age**; the supplied options/key obscure this.
- **Q15**: “copper was the only metal known” is false; copper is the diagnostic metal, not the sole one.
- **Q16**: Gilund is an exception to the general scarcity of burnt brick; a blanket statement cannot establish the printed answer.
- **Q18**: agriculture/domestication yes; iron is not a defining Neolithic technology. **Only i (a)**; ignore the handwritten tick on (c).
- Other core recall: **microliths—Mesolithic; food production—Neolithic; Ahar/Gilund—Chalcolithic; Burzahom—Neolithic; Bagor—Mesolithic; Belan—all three Stone Age phases**.

Four short Mains plans

- **Stone Age phases**: tool sequence + changing subsistence + one diagnostic site per phase; finish with overlapping regional dates.
- **Neolithic significance**: five examples—farming, herding, settled/storage-based villages, ground tools, pottery/crafts; add gradual regional transitions and aceramic exceptions.
- **Chalcolithic and Harappa**: separate technological category from chronological relationship; use Ahar–Banas, Malwa, Jorwe; avoid universal “all” statements.
- **Pottery as evidence**: manufacture/firing, decorative styles, diet/storage, exchange and relative dating; add limitations—pots alone cannot identify language, ethnicity or a fixed religion.

8. Last-minute recall

- **Lower = handaxe/cleaver → Middle = flakes → Upper = blades/burins**.
- **Meso = micro; Neo = food production + ground/polished tools; Chalco = copper + stone**.
- **Bagor—Kothari | Navdatoli—Narmada | Jorwe/Daimabad—Pravara | Inamgaon—Ghod**.
- **Burzahom—pits + human/animal burials | Chirand—antler tools | Budihal—feasting | southern Neolithic—ash mounds**.
- **No writing ≠ no history; no surviving evidence ≠ proof of absence.**